



FIGURE 4.11 A. Birrell, *Sir Robert Shirley* [graphic]. Engraving on wove paper.

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knowledge about remote civilizations. There is an obvious cultural coincidence, for instance, between carpet-making and storytelling among nomadic peoples, which these stories convey through their intricate plot development. They also tell fascinating stories about the traffic in diamonds, gold, and spices between the Indies, China, Arabia, and Western Europe that still wait to be unveiled. Rather than looking at the things of the *Nights* as colorful details in Sheherazade's tales or protagonists in the fantastic stories they make for themselves, we could explore, instead, their role as bearers of cultural knowledge *unintentionally* embedded in the fabric of the text. In such a reading, "historically and theoretically overdetermined material characteristics of objects are sought out beyond the immediate context in which they appear"⁸⁶ in order to

defetishize them and expose the power structures in which they are involved.

Thus, as Makdisi and Nussbaum sum up in their introduction to *The Arabian Nights in Historical Context: Between East and West*, "the *Nights* offered a particularly powerful vision of an Asiatic culture seemingly saturated with references to sensuality, extravagance, indulgence, violence, supernaturalism, and eroticism ... [and] added a supernatural dimension to the Enlightenment; the tales offered an avenue into modernity through its magical opposite, an alternative to European identity, and an antidote to neoclassicism."⁸⁷ However, reading such imports as an expression of European powers' disavowal of the East in order to "justify their conquest and rule over other peoples, particularly in Asia,"⁸⁸ is an oversimplification of a rather complicated process of cultural exchange. None of these descriptions of Arabia were caused by colonial "distortions," as Said feared, but by false attributions: "Arabian" was a misnomer that rarely described Arabia itself. While fictional narratives like *Arabian Nights' Entertainments* represented Arabia as a land of magic and exorbitant riches, they were too far-fetched to be part of a Westerner's belief system during the Age of Reason; rather, they were popularized because their wild fictionality turned them into bestsellers at the time. Such stories competed with descriptions of the Arabian Peninsula by travelers and traders who had visited the area and had unmediated contact with the local culture. However, while the Orientalist literature described Arabia in terms that emphasized its exoticism, magic, superstitions, extravagance, wealth, eroticism, excess, and myriads of other peculiarities that contrasted it with the European normativity, travel narratives created an "Arabian" identity that was generally congruent with the reality of the place.

86 Elaine Freedgood, "Introduction: Reading Things," in *The Idea in Things: Fugitive Meaning in the Victorian Novel* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2006), 5–6.

87 Makdisi and Nussbaum, introduction to *The Arabian Nights in Historical Context*, 5.

88 Ibid.